CIP — Business Description

Data Automation · Coresight Research

October 13, 2026

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Consumer Insight Portal — Business Description

How Coresight's consumer survey data is collected, checked, stored and made ready for analysis.

Version 1.0 · 13 October 2026 · Owner: Data Automation (Coresight Research)

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1. Summary

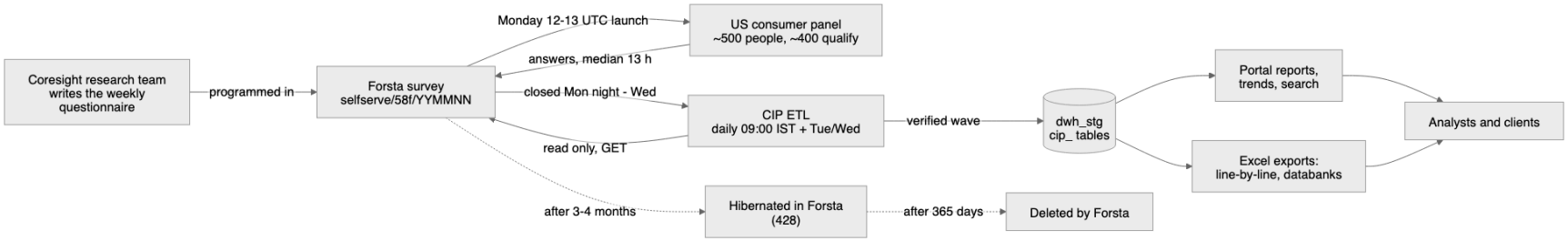
Coresight Research runs a **weekly survey of about 400 US consumers** on the Forsta Surveys platform (formerly Decipher), plus a handful of **annual studies** (Holiday, Amazon apparel, Online grocery, Back-to-school) and **client projects**. Until now the data team downloaded each week's results as Excel files, cleaned them by hand and pasted them into master workbooks.

The **Consumer Insight Portal (CIP)** replaces that manual work with an automated pipeline:

- Every survey is **read straight from Forsta** through its API (read only — nothing in Forsta is ever changed).
- Each weekly wave is **loaded within hours of closing**, checked answer by answer against Forsta, and only then made visible.
- The same cleaning the data team did by hand — qualified respondents only, labelled answers, age bands, generations, month — is **done automatically**, and proven equal to the team's own file.
- Everything is stored in the company data warehouse (`dwh_stg`, tables starting `cip_`), together with **history back to 2018** (SurveyMonkey 2018–2022, Qualtrics 2022–2025, Forsta 2025 onwards).
- All counting and percentage work is done **before** anyone opens a report, so reports and exports are instant.

Today (13 Oct 2026)	
Survey waves stored and verified	**318** — Forsta 31 · Qualtrics 142 · SurveyMonkey 145
Respondents	**≈166,000**
Individual answers	**≈23 million**
Forsta waves checked against Forsta	**31 of 31 identical** — 4,476,153 answers, 0 differences
Data team’s line-by-line file reproduced	**16 weeks identical** (3 errors found in the manual file)
Pipeline schedule	daily 09:00 IST, plus Tuesday and Wednesday 14:00 and 23:30 IST

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2. Where the survey data comes from

Platform	Years	How CIP receives it
Forsta Surveys (Decipher)	June 2025 → today	Directly from the Forsta API, automatically
Qualtrics	Aug 2022 → May 2025	From the warehouse's existing `dwh_sm*` tables (and one Excel export for May 2025)
SurveyMonkey	2018 → July 2022	From the same `dwh_sm*` tables

From October 2026 Forsta is the **only** live source. The old Excel route (download, clean, paste) is retired.

Important Forsta behaviours the business should know

- **One survey per week.** Each weekly wave is a new Forsta survey, named `selfserve/58f/YYMMNN` (e.g. `260907` = the wave of 28 September 2026).
- **Hibernation.** About 3–4 months after a survey closes, Forsta puts it to sleep ("hibernated"). Its data can no longer be read until someone **reactivates it by hand in Forsta**. 51 surveys are hibernated today.
- **Deletion.** Forsta deletes every survey **365 days** after it was created. After that, the warehouse is the only copy. This is why CIP loads every wave within hours of closing.

3. How Coresight's surveys are conducted — the patterns we identified

All findings below were measured from the 90 surveys Forsta holds (July 2025 – October 2026), not assumed.

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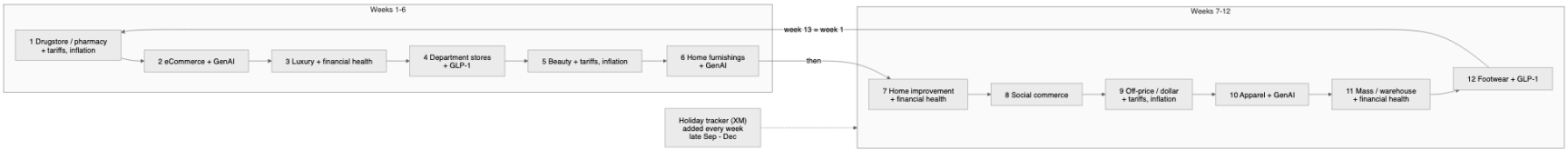
3.1 The weekly consumer survey (“Shopping and Spending”)

Feature	Pattern
Frequency	**Every week**
Launch	**Monday, 12:00–13:00 UTC** (≈ 17:30–18:30 IST) — 56 of 66 launches
Fielding	Closes between **Monday 20:00 and Wednesday 23:00 IST**; half close within **13 hours**
Sample	US adults 18+ from panel source 114; **~400 qualified** of ~500–800 who start
Title	`Shopping and Spending – inc <lead sector> + <topics> + <events>`
Wave label	The **Monday** of the first fielding day (e.g. 2026-10-05)

3.2 The 12-week sector rotation

Every weekly survey “leads” with one retail sector, and the sectors **rotate in a fixed order**. Each sector comes back **exactly every 12 weeks** (measured: Drugstore, eCommerce, Dept stores, Beauty — 12, 12, 12, 12, 12 weeks apart). This is why Beauty, Home furnishings and the other sectors appear to be “separate surveys”: they are the same weekly survey taking turns.

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#	Lead sector	Usual add-on topic	Recent waves
1	Drugstore / pharmacy	Tariffs + inflation	Jun 8, Aug 31 2026
2	eCommerce	GenAI	Jun 15, Sep 7
3	Luxury	Financial health	Jun 22, Sep 14
4	Department stores	GLP-1	Jun 29, Sep 21
5	Beauty	Tariffs + inflation	Jul 6, Sep 28
6	Home furnishings	GenAI	Jul 13, Oct 5
7	Home improvement / DIY	Financial health	Jul 20, **Oct 12**
8	Social commerce	—	Jul 27, Oct 19 (expected)
9	Off-price / dollar stores	Tariffs + inflation	Aug 3, Oct 26 (expected)
10	Apparel	GenAI	Aug 10, Nov 2 (expected)
11	Mass merchants / warehouse clubs	Financial health	Aug 17, Nov 9 (expected)
12	Footwear	GLP-1	Aug 24, Nov 16 (expected)

How to apply it: the next lead sector can be predicted (the Oct 12 wave is Home improvement, exactly as the rotation said); a sector’s trend is read every 12 weeks; a Beauty analysis stacks the Beauty waves (Jul 2025, Oct 2025, Jan, Apr, Jul, Sep 2026).

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3.3 Seasonal, event and topical modules

Kind	What it is	Pattern
Holiday tracker	Weekly holiday-shopping status, purchases, retailers (questions XM1–XM3)	Every week through the season: **2025 Oct 13** → **Dec 22** (9 waves); **2026 from Sep 28** (wave 1), Oct 5 (wave 2)
Holiday outlook	Spending plans vs last year, inflation, bipolar preferences (HX1–HX6)	With Beauty and Footwear waves
Recurring topics	Tariffs (TF), inflation (IN), GLP-1 (GP), GenAI (G, GU), financial health (F), MidEast gas price shock (Apr–Aug 2026)	Paired with the sectors above
Events	Prime Day, Big Deal Days, Labor Day, Halloween, Black Friday, Easter, July 4th, Father's Day, Super Bowl, FIFA World Cup …	One-off "retro" or "plans" modules near the date

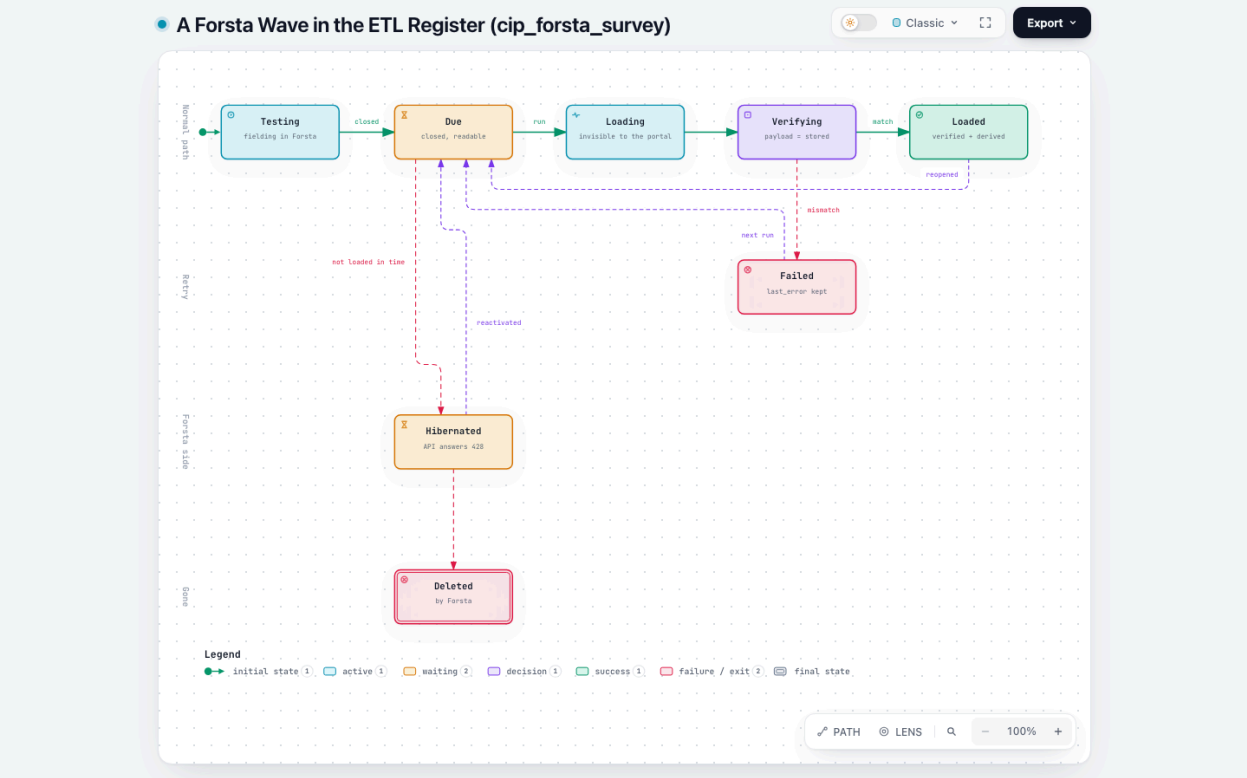
Holiday tracker waves are **numbered within the season**, so this year's wave 2 is compared with last year's wave 2.

3.4 Annual and client studies

Study	When	Size
Holiday shopping (annual)	September (2025: Sep 30; 2026: Sep 10)	≈2,000 qualified
Amazon apparel (annual)	April	≈2,000
Online grocery (annual)	May	≈2,000
Back-to-school	June	≈500
Client studies (T-Mobile, Zebra, APTOS, Rokbot, Simbe, ARC, Board)	ad hoc	100–300 each

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3.5 Survey status and lifecycle



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4. What each survey collects

4.1 The core questions — asked every week

Code	Question (Forsta wording)	Answer type
q1	Which, if any, of these have you done in the past two weeks?	Tick all that apply — 13–15 activities (met friends, restaurant, mall, gym, bar, trip …)
q2	Which, if any, of these categories have you purchased IN A STORE in the past two weeks?	Tick all — 18 categories
q3	And which, if any, of these categories have you purchased ONLINE in the past two weeks?	Tick all — 18 categories
q4	Which, if any, of these retailers have you bought any FOOD products from in the past two weeks?	Tick all — 16 retailers (Walmart, Amazon, Costco, Kroger group, Aldi …)
q5	Which, if any, of these retailers have you bought any NONFOOD products from in the past two weeks?	Tick all — 14 retailers (Amazon, Walmart, Target, TJX group, Temu …)
CS1	Considering your discretionary income …, do you think your household situation will be better or worse?	Much worse … Much better, Don’t know
CS2	And thinking about the economy overall over the next 12 months, do you think things will be better or worse?	Same scale
D1	What is your gender?	Male, Female, Non-binary / third gender, Prefer not to say
D2	What is your age?	Single years 18–69, “70 or more”, “Under 18” (age **bands** until Oct 2025)

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Code	Question (Forsta wording)	Answer type
D3	What is your relationship status?	Single, new relationship, long-term relationship, prefer not to say
D4	With which ethnicity do you most closely identify?	5 groups + prefer not to say
D5	What was your total household income last year?	6 bands from under $25,000 to $200,000+
D6	Area of primary residence	Urban, Suburban, Rural
D7	Political philosophy	5 statements (Republican … Democratic)
D8	State of primary residence	50 states + DC (2-letter codes)

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4.2 Module questions (examples)

Module	Codes	Example question
Beauty	BT1–BT15	Have you purchased any beauty products (whether for men or women) in the past three months?
Holiday tracker	XM1–XM3	What is the current status of your holiday shopping?
Holiday outlook	HX1–HX6	Looking back, how did your spending for the 2025 holiday season compare to 2024?
Tariffs	TF	What impact, if any, do you think tariffs have on you personally?
Inflation	IN	Have you noticed any recent price changes in retail?
GLP-1	GP	Are you currently using a GLP-1 drug like Ozempic?
GenAI	G, GU	Which, if any, of the following AI tools have you used in the last two weeks?
Apparel	AP, DNM, R	Have you purchased any clothing or apparel accessories in the past three months?
Home furnishings / improvement	HF, HI	Have you purchased any home-furnishing/décor products in the past three months?
Department stores / Luxury / Footwear	DP, LX, FW	Have you purchased any luxury products in the past three months?
Social commerce / eCommerce	SC, EC	Have you used social media as part of the overall shopping process …?
Off-price / Dollar / Mass	O, DS, M	Have you purchased from a dollar store retailer in the past three months?

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Module	Codes	Example question
Financial health	F	How long could you cover all of your bills and expenses using just your savings?
Events	APR, PDR, BD, BF, LDR, HW, E, ID, FDR …	Did you browse/purchase on Amazon.com during Prime Day?

A typical weekly wave carries **50–80 analysis questions** and ~400 data columns.

4.3 What else Forsta records per respondent

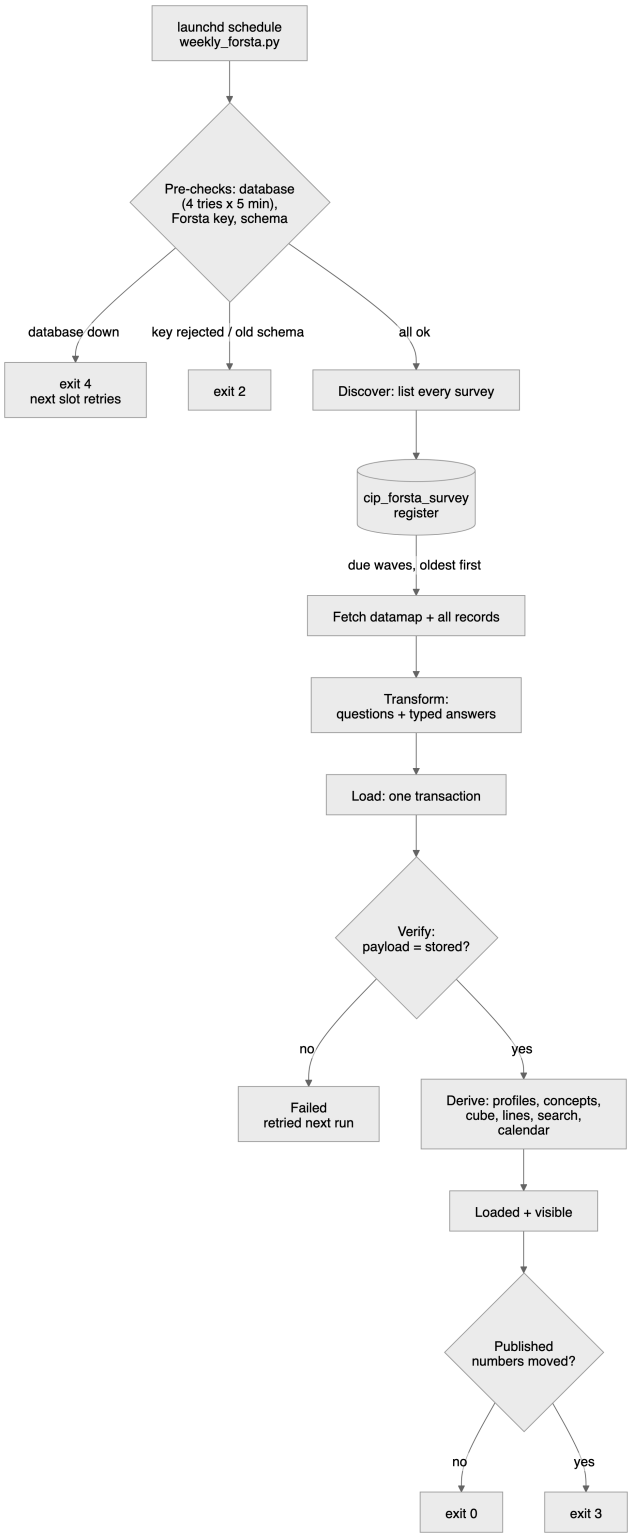
Field	Meaning	Kept?
status	1 terminated · 2 over quota · 3 **qualified** · 4 partial	Kept (all statuses loaded; reports use qualified)
date, start_date	Completion and start time	Kept
qtime	Interview length (seconds)	Kept
device, OS, browser (vmobiledevice, vos, vbrowser)	How they took it	Kept (as technical fields)
RID (panel id)	Identifies the panelist	**Only as an irreversible code (sha256)**
userAgent, url, session, dcua, IP	Browser string, link, session, fingerprint	**Never stored**

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5. How the pipeline works (business

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view)



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1. **Connect** — the pipeline signs in to Forsta with the company's API key (kept in a protected settings file).
2. **Discover** — it lists every survey Forsta holds and decides what is new: closed and not yet loaded = *due*.
3. **Extract** — for each due wave it downloads the questionnaire definition and every respondent's answers.
4. **Transform** — it turns codes into a clean, consistent shape, removes personal data, and recognises each question type (tick-all lists, grids, statements, numbers, open text).
5. **Load** — it writes the wave into the warehouse in one step, hidden from reports while it is being written.
6. **Verify** — it proves every respondent and every answer equals what Forsta sent. Only then is the wave shown.
7. **Prepare** — it pre-computes everything reports need: demographic bands, links to the same question in other waves, counts by gender / age / generation / income / region, the line-by-line table, search, and the calendar.

When it runs: daily at 09:00 IST, plus Tuesday and Wednesday at 14:00 and 23:30 IST — so a wave closing on Monday night or Tuesday is in the warehouse the same day. If the network is down, it retries for 15 minutes and then waits for the next slot.

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6. What is stored

Business object	What it holds	Table
Survey register	Every Forsta survey and what the pipeline did with it	`cip_forsta_survey`
Survey calendar	Each survey's lead sector, topics, seasonal tracker and wave number	`cip_wave_module`
Wave	One week's survey	`cip_survey`
Questions, answers lists, codes	The questionnaire of each wave	`cip_question`, `cip_item`, `cip_option`, `cip_field`
Respondent	One interview (status, time, device)	`cip_respondent`
Profile	Gender, age band, generation, income, region …	`cip_profile`
Answers	Every answer of every respondent	`cip_answer`
Concepts	"The same question" across waves and platforms	`cip_concept`, `cip_concept_map`
Pre-computed counts	Every answer × demographic cut × segment	`cip_agg_cell`
Line-by-line	The data team's weekly file, rebuilt automatically	`cip_tracker_line`
Audit	Every load, its counts and errors	`cip_load_log`

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7. Replicating the data team's manual work

The data team's cleaned file ("Weekly Line-By-Line Survey Data", 36 weeks Feb–Sep 2026) is now produced by the pipeline with the same rules:

Team rule	Automated
Qualified respondents only (~400 / week)	✓
One column per tick-all item, label when chosen, blank when not	✓
Headers "Activities:", "Purchased In-store:", "Purchased Online:", "Food:", "Non-food:"	✓
Month = first day of the wave's month	✓
Age Range 18-29 / 30-44 / 45-60 / over 60	✓
Generation GenZ 18-28, Millennial 29-44, GenX 45-60, Boomer 61+	✓
State as 2-letter code	✓
Panel session id	Not carried (personal data)

Compared on the 16 weeks both hold (≈6,400 respondents × ≈90 columns): **identical**, apart from three errors in the manual file — July rows dated "2026-07-26", "Under 18" respondents placed in "over 60 / Boomer", and two activities (cinema, live performance) missing for 10 weeks. Those go back to the data team.

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8. Quality, privacy and governance

- **Read only.** The pipeline never changes, reactivates or deletes anything in Forsta.
- **Proof before display.** A wave is visible only after it matches Forsta exactly. All 31 Forsta waves were re-checked on 8 Oct 2026: 4,476,153 answers, 0 differences.

- **Personal data.** Browser strings, links, sessions, device fingerprints and IP addresses are never stored; the panel id only as an irreversible code.
- **Small bases** (fewer than 50 people) are flagged in outputs; every percentage carries its own base.
- **Audit trail.** Every load is logged with counts and errors (`cip_load_log`).

What still needs a person

Task	Who
Close each weekly survey in Forsta	Research / Forsta owner
Reactivate hibernated surveys when history is needed (e.g. the 2025 holiday tracker for “vs last year”)	Forsta owner
Review uncertain question matches on the Mappings page	Data team

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9. Glossary

Term	Meaning
Wave	One fielding of a survey — for the tracker, one week
Lead sector	The retail sector a weekly wave focuses on (12 rotate)
Module	A block of questions on one topic (BT = beauty, XM = holiday tracker …)
Qualified	A respondent who completed and passed the screener (status 3)
Base	The number of people a percentage is calculated on
Hibernated	A Forsta survey put to sleep; unreadable until reactivated
Concept	The same question recognised across waves and platforms, even when its code changes
Cube	Pre-computed counts so reports never re-count raw answers
ETL	Extract, Transform, Load — the automated pipeline

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10. Diagrams

Diagram	Editable (Excalidraw)	Interactive (Archify)
Business process	`docs/diagrams/01-business-process.excalidraw`	—
ETL end to end	`docs/diagrams/02-etl-end-to-end.excalidraw`	`.archify/architecture-forsta-etl-20261008/forsta-etl.html`
One scheduled run	—	`.archify/sequence-scheduled-run-20261013/scheduled-run.html`
Survey lifecycle	—	`.archify/lifecycle-forsta-wave-20261008/forsta-wave.html`
Database design	`docs/diagrams/06-data-model.excalidraw`	`.archify/architecture-cip-database-20261008/cip-database.html`
Data sources	`docs/diagrams/07-data-sources.excalidraw`	—
Survey cadence	`docs/diagrams/08-survey-cadence.excalidraw`	—

Open `.excalidraw` files at excalidraw.com (File → Open) to edit; open `.html` files in any browser.

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